

**Examining the Role of Music in Advertisements and its Effect on
Consumer Choice Behavior: A Close Examination of Classical
Characteristics**

**To What Extent Does Music, Specifically Classical Music
Characteristics, In Advertisements Affect Consumer Choice
Behavior?**

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Abstract

Introduction

- Mention Brandon Kaplan
- The Classical period
 - an emphasis on elegance and balance. short well-balanced melodies and clear-cut question and answer phrases. mainly homophonic textures (melody plus accompaniment) but with some use of counterpoint (where two or more melodic lines are combined)
-

Chapters

1. Term Definitions

1.1 Tempo, Pitch, Tessiture, Texture, and Instrumentation

Tempo is the speed of the pulse or beat of a piece of music. Tempo is often used to convey a feeling, as well as the genre it classifies in. Some styles of music tend to have a specific tempo. For example, romantic ballads typically have a slow tempo (>76 BPM), whilst disco music typically has a fast tempo (<120 BPM). To further understand tempo, one must have an understanding of beat. A piece of music can have a consistent tempo while varying in the amounts of beats per bar. The time signature of a piece demonstrates the meter of composition or beats per measure constrained in tempo. Tempo can be generally classified in seven different markings on a music score: Grave (slow and solemn), Lento/Largo (40-60, very slow), Larghetto (60-66, fairly slow), Adagio (66-76, slow), Andante (76-108, walking pace), Moderato (108-120, fairly quickly), Allegro (120-168, fast), and Presto (168-200, very fast).

Several researchers have come to the general conclusion that fast music is considered to be happier and/or more pleasing than slow music. Faster tempos reflect exhilarating and joyous feelings. Slower tempos tend to evoke tranquil, and/or solemn descriptors. Studies have shown that there is a positive relationship between effect and musical pace. The range of favored tempo lies between 70 to 110 BPM (beats per minute), which can be represented on a bell curve. However, the range of preference may vary depending on the purpose or context of the tempo. An argument can be made for the natural ‘rhythm’ of the human heart lying between 60 to 110 BPM,¹ thus humans would generally prefer a tempo in that range. Firm rhythms were deemed more serious; flowing rhythms were felt to be happier, playful, and animated. Staccato-notes, as

¹ Edward R. Laskowski, M.D. “2 Easy, Accurate Ways to Measure Your Heart Rate.” *Mayo Clinic*, Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research, 2 Oct. 2020, <https://www.mayoclinic.org/healthy-lifestyle/fitness/expert-answers/heart-rate/faq-20057979#:~:text=A%20normal%20resting%20heart%20rate%20for%20adults%20ranges%20from%2060,to%2040%20beats%20per%20minute.>

shown in *Figure 1*, would exemplify the impression of liveliness, energy, and animation. Contradictory music with an uneven rhythm was perceived to express exaltation.²



Figure 1. Staccato Note Scale in Treble and Bass Clef

Pitch is the highness or lowness of a sound. Certain feelings can be associated with different pitches, chords, or harmonies. In an interview with Brandon Kaplan, he specified the major keys or modes that can be associated with happier mediums. Furthermore, music with a higher pitch can be heard as more exciting than a piece of music with a lower pitch, which can be perceived as sorrowful. On the contrary, a minor mode or key has an aggressive or mysterious quality to the major's playful and happy expression. Consonant harmonies can be characterized as playful, while dissonant harmonies can be described as agitating or sad. Within the pitch, melodies can play a role in the feeling association. Ascending melodies can be heard as rousing, whereas descending melodies can be heard as somber.

Musical texture is the combination of different musical building blocks, melodies, harmonies, and rhythms, along with tempo and timbre. Texture falls into four categories, monophonic, polyphonic, homophonic, and heterophonic, but one of the most common textures is homophonic textures. Homophonic textures have a main melodic line which is supported with harmony. Polyphonic is when multiple voices play the same notes or beats. Heterophonic has a melodic line that is accompanied by different version of the same melody. Monophonic textures have 1 voice or multiple voice singing the same melody. Timbre or the "tone color" identifies the different instruments playing the same pitch. For example, if a saxophone and violin were to both play a middle C, one could still tell the instruments apart.

Instrumentation is the choice of instruments for a musical piece. As a composer, he or she would want to find a balance or blend between all the instruments playing to achieve a cohesive composition. According to Brandon Kaplan, he specified that instrument timbre can conjure different feelings or moods. For example, the violin is a gushed and very emotional and romantic instrument that can play a melody very well with lots of vibratos. He mentioned that brands that want to convey their company or product as luxurious, expensive, and or refined will often have a violin in their advertisement. The piano or keyboard is the workhorse of every aspect of the score. Kaplan mentions that the keyboard or piano can be used as a percussion instrument; as

² Music, Mood, and Marketing

highly romantic; as a melody; or as an accompanying melody. A unique instrument such as the harp is more limited to how people use it, but it conjures elegance and high refinement, not only in the music but the instrument itself.

1.2 Cadence

Cadence is a two-chord progression at the end of a phrase of music.³ There are four primary types of cadences to consider: authentic, half, plagal, and deceptive. Authentic cadence is when the Dominant (fifth note) to the Tonic (first and last note). A perfect authentic cadence *Figure 3*, is when the chords are in root position (lowest note played) and ends on the tonic which will be the highest note of the final chord. Imperfect authentic cadence (IAC), shown in *Figure 5*, is when the highest pitch is not the tonic, one or both chords are inverted, or the fifth note is replaced with a diminished seventh and the cadence still ends on a tonic first. A half cadence (HC), shown in *Figure 3*, is when the song ends on the dominant fifth regardless of the preceding chord. It sounds incomplete and is considered a weak cadence.

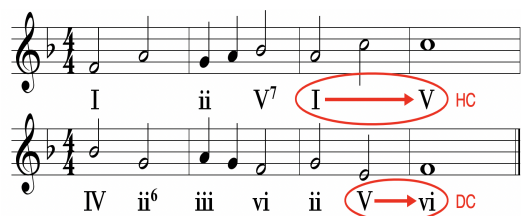


Figure 3. Half and Authentic Cadence

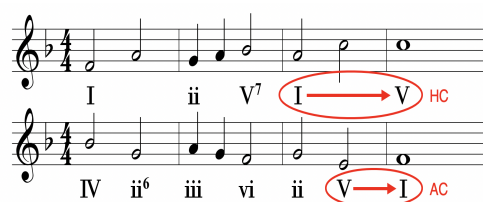


Figure 4. Half and Deceptive Cadence

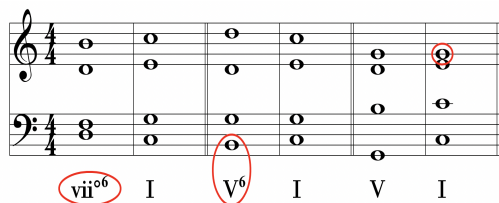


Figure 5. Imperfect Authentic Cadence



Figure 6. Plagal Cadence

Cadence	Progression
Half	ANY → V
Authentic	V → I
Plagal	IV → I
Deceptive	V → NOT I

Figure 7. Half, Authentic, Plagal, and Deceptive Cadence with Chord Progression

³ <https://www.musicnotes.com/now/tips/cadences-in-music-theory-the-4-types-explained/>

A plagal cadence (PC), shown in *Figure 6*, is when the sound ends from the subdominant fourth to the tonic first. A deceptive cadence (DC), shown in *Figure 4*, is when a phrase ends from the dominant fifth to any other chord other than the tonic first. This creates the image that the phrase does not come to a resolution.

1.3 Diegetic and Non-Diegetic Music

Diegetic sound is sound that is visible in the media setting. Non-diegetic sound is sound that comes from a soundtrack or score that is not visible in the medium. Diegetic can simply be someone talking, objects rustling, or music that is visible played on the screen. Diegetic sounds in film can create certain assumptions by the audience about what specific time and place the film is happening. Non-diegetic sounds are typically used to stylize a film and assist the audience in the emotion that is conveyed through the media. Diegetic sounds are used to be a part of the scene rather than displaying certain effects or emotions.

2. Music and Choice Behavior

2.1 Classical Conditioning

Classical conditioning suggests that positive attitudes towards an advertised product (conditioned stimulus) might develop through its association in a commercial with other stimuli that are reacted to positively. Attractive colors, pleasant music, and humor are examples of potential unconditioned stimuli in a commercial.⁴

2.2 Factors

There are multiple stimuli that can influence classical conditioning. Lack of consumer awareness is an unconditional stimulus in an advertisement that could affect his or her attitudes towards a product. For example, it may be more logical to say that you like the product more after seeing a commercial because you now believe it has XYZ characteristics, rather than because you liked the music in the commercial. Thus evidence supporting classical conditioning is unlikely to emerge in self-reports.⁵ Arousal is another key factor that can alter classical conditioning in consumer behavior. Arousal stimuli such as sex, music, color, and humor can reinforce the information in a commercial. Through these methods, a greater understanding of the product creates a more positive attitude towards the product. A recent study by the Foot, Cone, and Belding ad agency found that music and visuals that accompanied a product recalled a stronger desire or influence to purchase that product. Thus, the paper further suggests that background features of a commercial advertisement can influence a product choice and can conjure positive emotions associated with the advertised product through classical conditioning.

⁴ The Effects of Music In Advertising On Choice Behavior: A Classical Conditioning Approach

⁵ The Effects of Music In Advertising On Choice Behavior: A Classical Conditioning Approach

3. Marketing

3.1 Nonbehavioral Studies

Reported below are some of the first reviews on nonbehavioral outcomes of music in marketing contexts, for example, changes in effect, purchase intention, and recall. Wintle (1978) tested a series of experiments to see if there was any correlation between music and emotional response to television commercials. From Wintle's study, he concluded that there are three factors of subjective expression that are conveyed between the music and the viewer in commercials: an activity factor, a pleasantness factor, and a potency/personal relevance factor.⁶ Simpkins and Smith (1974) concurred that the compatibility of background music alongside the audience's preference affected the likeness of a message or commercial. Holbrook and Anand (1988, 1985) studied the relationship between musical tempo and affect. They concluded that as tempo increased to a certain degree, so did affect on the viewer. Holbrook and Anand reiterate that tempo arousal can be plot on a bell-curve depending on the situational or contextual preferred music pace. Stewart and Furse (1986) analyzed over one thousand commercials and found that music evoked an auditory memory device; music in commercials had a significant positive relationship with recall and comprehension that would strengthen the association for new than for established products.⁷ Viewers and respondents made stronger personal connections with ads using the major or mixed modes. Faster tempos were also generally favored in the responses.

4. Analysis of Specific Advertisements and the Music Chosen

4.1 Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, *Marriage of Figaro Overture* (ALFA-ROMEO AD)

For case study number one I will be using an Alfa-Romeo ad that uses Mozart's *Marriage of Figaro Overture*. The instruments used in this piece of music are two flutes, two oboes, two clarinets, two bassoons, two horns, two trumpets, timpani, and strings; however, the piano cords will

- Chord Progression
 - On paper
- Structure (b/c of calls and responses)
 - "The **form** of the **Overture** to *The Marriage of Figaro* is an abridged sonata form structure. The three section sonata form that Mozart uses for the overture to *The Magic Flute* and *Don Giovanni* is shortened here to just two main sections. A smaller, shorter sonata is often called a **sonatina**."
 - " *The Marriage of Figaro* launches immediately into the first theme of the overture, a whispered **pianissimo** (very quiet), very fast and agitated passage, suggesting perhaps, the conspiratorial whispers and intrigue to come. The hectic **presto** (very fast) tempo marking of the overture conveys the frenetic, breathless pace and buoyant mood of the opera as a whole."

⁶ Music, Mood, and Marketing

⁷ Music, Mood, and Marketing

- Tempo
 - 141 bpm
- Harmony
 - Homophonic; consonant
- Genre/Period
 - Classical
- Timbre
 - String quartet

4.1 Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, *Queen of the Night Aria (VOLVO AD)*

For case study number one I will be using a Volvo ad that uses Mozart's 'Queen of the Night Aria.' The instruments originally used to support the coloratura soprano in this aria are two flutes (one doubling on piccolo), two oboes, two clarinets (doubling basset horns), two bassoons, two horns, two trumpets, three trombones (alto, tenor, and bass), timpani, and strings. Queen of the Night Aria is perhaps the most well known of opera arias, with a memorable melody, virtuosic technique, and high range.⁸ Mozart is generally considered to be a composer who favored well-balanced phrases which give his pieces a feeling of stability. This can be seen in many of his works, such as 'Queen of the Night Aria' where he uses the call and response form as seen in *Figure 9 below*.

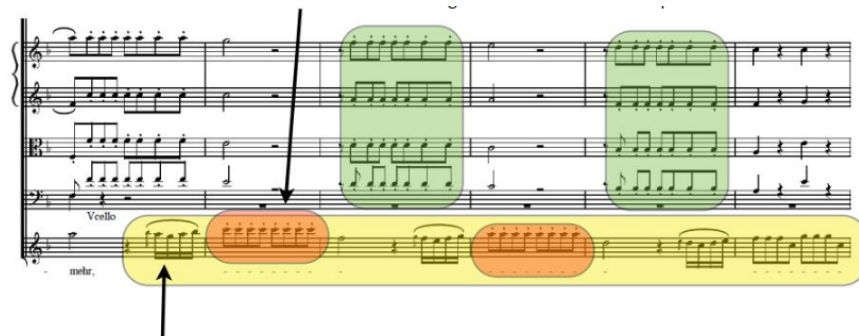


Figure 9. Call and Response Highlighted in *Queen of the Night Aria*

This form provides stability because the call and response technique provides a structure within the score. The call and response form adds depth and texture. When the soprano vocalist approaches a cadence in her phrase the orchestra is quick to respond with staccato eight notes. In this piece of music, the soprano singer utilizes her voice as an instrument and creates a conjunct melody. The tempo of this piece is allegro, thus this piece exudes exhilaration and joyous feeling

⁸ Son, J.W. Pepper and. "The Queen of the Night from Le Nozze Di Figaro." *The Queen of the Night from Le Nozze Di Figaro (T | J.W. Pepper Sheet Music*, <https://www.jwpepper.com/The-Queen-of-the-Night-from-Le-Nozze-di-Figaro/10355502.item#.YiE9MxPMLb1>.

corresponding to the studies mentioned above. The staccato notes, as shown in *Figure 10*, would exemplify the impression of liveliness, energy, and animation.

Figure 10. Violin Staccato Notes Highlighted in Gray

It is interesting to note that the composer for the Volvo advert made a decision to cut out in *Figure 11*, and change the key to Eb major in the score. This music score demonstrates a perfect authentic cadence in the last phrase of the piece at the root position V going to a root position I, shown in measures 14-15 of *Figure 12*.

Figure 11. The Queen of the Night Aria *Note: Green boxes indicate sections of the piece that remained in Volvo's composition, while red boxes indicate sections of the piece that were cut out*

Figure 12. Transcription of The Queen of the Night Aria Volvo AD Composition

In the ad, Volvo chooses to have diegetic music. As I previously mentioned before, many advertisements do not utilize diegetic music; however, Volvo displays the lead vocalists throughout the duration of the advertisement. She is wearing an elegant orange dress and large diamond earrings to portray herself in the advertisement as refined and luxurious. Furthermore, the ad focuses on the message, “Can you design an SUV for an aria,” which solidifies the music to product connection. Volvo wants to associate its product with a musical piece that projects opulence. As the video progress, the camera pans to shots of the Volvo Boxer & Wilkins stereo system. Because the music in the advert is very refined and clear, one can make the association to the stereo system housed in the Volvo XC90. At the end of the ad, it mentions “the 2019 Volvo XC90 is designed for an aria, rock stars, conductors, jazz trios, beatboxers, and for you.” There is a select audience for the car and demand to meet expectations. The aim of this advertisement is to equate the Volvo XC90 with luxury and high-end car models. Thus, using “The Queen of the Night Aria” successfully associates and conjures this effect through its balanced and energetic score, as well as its use of visual representation within the advert.

4.3 Mozart Rondo Alla Turca (HYUNDAI SONATA AD)

For case study number three I will be using a Hyundai Sonata ad that uses Mozart’s ‘Rondo Alla Turca,’ or ‘Turkish March.’ This piece is a piano sonata, thus the piano is the sole instrument.

Mozart is generally considered to be a composer who favored well-balanced phrases which give his pieces a feeling of stability. This can be seen in many of his works, such as ‘Rondo Alla Turca’ where he uses the repetition form as seen in *Figure 6 below*.

- Tempo
 - 116 bpm 144 in the ad
- Cadence
 - Imperfect authentic cadence and perfect authentic cadence

4.2 Johanne Strauss II, The Blue Danube Waltz (CLEANER AD)

- Instrumentation
 - Cellos, horns in the tonic (D major), and the harp

4.3 Beethoven Symphony NO. 5, 1st movement (COCA-COLA AD)

5. Counter Argument

5.1 The Effects of Background Music in Advertising: A Reassessment

“Subjects were more likely to select a specific color of a pen if that pen had been paired with pleasant rather than unpleasant music.” “textbooks now cite the experiment as proof that consumer preferences can be classically conditioned” “Gorn was able to obtain surprisingly strong effects... “Gorn’s subjects were almost three times as likely to choose the advertised pen after it had been paired once with pleasant music”

Experiment 1: “Two recordings were chosen (a Mozart overture and a selection by Milhaud)... (X=5.18 for Mozart and X=2.07 for Milhaud)” “ for seven pen colors on a student sample. The two pen colors with means closest to the overall mean were yellow and white)

6. Discussion

6.1 Possible Propositions

Safely Conclude that

- Human beings non randomly assign emotional meaning to music
- Human beings experience non-random affective reactions to music
- Music used in marketing-related contexts is capable of evoking nonrandom affective and behavioral responses in consumers

P₁: The components of music are capable of having main as well as interaction effects on moods, cognitions, and behaviors of interests in marketers

P₂: The structural nature of music is related to its ability to achieve various purposes

P₃: The emotions perceived to be expressed in musical stimuli are capable of evoking corresponding affective reactions in listeners

- There is little debate that music can be perceived as expressing emotion-like qualities. It is more radical to suggest that properly structured music can generate particular emotions.

P₄: The influence of music on persuasiveness is greatest under conditions of peripheral route processing and low cognitive involvement

P₅: Several variables moderate the relationship between music and consumer responses

P₆: Some responses to music are learned whereas others are inherent⁹

⁹ Music, Mood, and Marketing

Conclusion

References and Bibliography

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<https://www.supremetracks.com/how-to-orchestrate-music>